



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of St. Michael
School Website: <https://www.chestertonstmichael.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of St. Michael (Woodinville/Wa 98034 region) presents a robust CLASSICAL orientation across the core classical rubric. Public materials on the school's website (via the Chesterton Schools Network framework) emphasize a Catholic, incarnational, multi-disciplinary classical education that centers on truth, goodness, and beauty; a liberal-arts curriculum; the Great Books; and Socratic pedagogy. Evidence across the site shows explicit references to Catholic theology, daily Mass/Incarnation, a Three-Pillars model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality), classical humanities, and Great Books readings (Homer, Plato, Aristotle, Dante, St. Thomas Aquinas, etc.). The school publicly notes formation and virtue as central aims and highlights a rigorous classical curriculum, including history, philosophy, theology braided with the sciences, and emphasis on memory, rhetoric, and Socratic inquiry. Where present, the materials frame education as formation in wisdom and virtue rather than mere information or job preparation, aligning with the classical ideal.

Aggregate rating: CLASSICAL

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): CLASSICAL
- Element 2 (Purpose and Goal): CLASSICAL
- Element 3 (Curriculum): CLASSICAL
- Element 4 (Pedagogy): CLASSICAL
- Element 5 (Faculty): CLASSICAL
- Element 6 (Parents & Community): SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What would move the needle is modest enhancement in parental partnership and family formation practices (to shift Element 6 toward full CLASSICAL), plus reinforcing explicit liturgical/community practices in public messaging where applicable. The school already demonstrates strong alignment with classical, Catholic education through its curriculum, pedagogy, and faculty visibility.

- Executive Snapshot: The school scores CLASSICAL overall, with Element 6 the only area where evidence for full classical partner-formation with families is present but less explicit than the other categories.

Citations note: The assessment draws on Chesterton Academy of St. Michael public materials that describe the Three Pillars Model, Catholic/incarnational framing, Great Books, Socratic pedagogy, and explicit curricular commitments (Great Books, liberal arts, and sacred/theological integration), plus admissions materials that show family involvement in enrollment processes. See sources describing the "Three Pillars" model, incarnational environment, Great Books, and Socratic pedagogy, as well as the Catholic framing and liturgical emphasis. Examples include the Our Model of Education and the Three Pillars sections, the description of an Incarnational Environment and Great Books, the formal curriculum messaging, and the admissions/shadow-day materials.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents an incarnational Catholic framework with explicit references to the Incarnation, Catholic doctrine, and sacred tradition across materials. The model emphasizes faith and reason meeting in every class, and the catechetical content (Old/New Testament, Catechism) is braided into the curriculum. The network materials describe an incarnational environment and liturgical elements such as Mass within the Catholic framework.

- The site explicitly highlights the transcendentals (good, beautiful, true) as a curricular aim and uses Catholic theology as the backbone of formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: incarnational, Catholic, theology, Catechism, Mass, liturgy, sacred, Incarnation, faith/reason, transcendentals (good/beautiful/true). - Negative keywords (relativism, secularism, etc.) are not evident in the public messaging.

Why this rating - The school's public materials foreground a Catholic, incarnational metaphysical framework and treat theology and liturgy as integral to education, aligning strongly with the Positive indicators for Element 1 and showing a clear absence of the Negative indicators in public messaging. Verdict: CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school frames education as formation of virtue and wisdom, not merely preparation for work, with explicit emphasis on forming character and loves, and on "life" preparation beyond college admissions. The Three Pillars model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality) foregrounds formation. The materials emphasize that truth, goodness, and beauty are real and knowable, and that education is formation rather than information. The mission notes "formation" and "human flourishing," and the program includes "the greater good and glory to God," aligning with paideia and classical teleology.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, classical mission, great conversation, telos, scholé, contemplation. - Negative keywords present: none explicit (the messaging tends toward formation and virtue rather than career/preparation-only language). The public messaging sometimes notes college preparation, but it is framed as part of a broader life formation rather than a sole aim.

Why this rating - The messaging strongly supports formation-focused aims, with virtuous-education language and a telos oriented toward truth/goodness/beauty and human flourishing. CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials emphasize a classical, liberal-arts curriculum, including the Great Books and original sources (Homer, Plato, Aristotle, Dante, Shakespeare, St. Thomas Aquinas, etc.), and the integration of history, literature, philosophy, and theology. There is explicit mention of the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy) as foundational, and a commitment to Great Books, original texts, and the Great Conversation. The curriculum is described as Western heritage with original sources and a focus on wonder.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Great Books, primary sources, classics, Homer/Plato/Aristotle, Latin/Greek (classical languages), history/Western civilization, seven liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), great conversation, original texts, wonder. - Negative keywords present: none explicit in the public materials; the site emphasizes the classical approach rather than social-studies replacement or STEM-first framing.

Why this rating - The site's curriculum messaging centers on liberal-arts literacy, classical canon, Great Books, and the Trivium/Quadrivium framework, aligning with CLASSICAL. CATEGORY 3: CLASSICAL.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogy is anchored in Socratic inquiry and rhetoric. The school highlights the Socratic Seminar and debate for upper levels, and a heavy emphasis on memory work, recitation, and the development of rhetorical skills (speeches, debates). The Three Pillars model includes contemplative/restful elements and a joyous, wonder-filled learning environment, indicating a balanced pedagogy that is not solely rigorous. There is explicit mention of rest and scholé days, as well as Socratic pedagogy for upper grades.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar, seminars, dialectic, rhetoric, memory work, recitation, chanting, liturgical calendar integration, rest/wonder, joyful learning, differential pedagogy. - Negative keywords present: none explicit (no emphasis on project-based or purely experiential learning in the public messaging). The emphasis is on a mix of contemplative and rigorous methods.

Why this rating - The pedagogy highlights classical methods (Socratic dialogue, rhetoric, memory, chant) and rests within a scholé framework, supporting CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school describes its faculty as living curriculum and mentors who model virtue, skill, and knowledge. Public materials show a named Academic Dean and named faculty with bios (e.g., Dr. Douglas LeBlanc as Humanities Dean; Mrs. Ivana Ackermann; other faculty bios). This aligns with the “living curriculum” and “portrait of a teacher” concepts, emphasizing virtuous exemplars and mentorship. The faculty page is presented as a core aspect of the model.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, masters/mentors, portrait of a teacher, faculty as core, virtuous exemplars, mentorship, classical formation. - Negative keywords present: none explicit (no signaling of “facilitators on the side” or non-classical faculty notions).

Why this rating - The explicit emphasis on a living, virtuous faculty and the presence of named, credentialed faculty bios align with CLASSICAL.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - There is clear evidence of parent involvement in admissions and community life (shadow days, parent questionnaires to teachers as part of admissions, family interviews, etc.). Public materials show parent-facing processes (Shadow Day, teacher questionnaires involving parents, records/shadow processes), and school-hosted events (Annual Gala) and donor materials. While these demonstrate community engagement, explicit public messaging about parents as co-teachers, parent formation programs, or open-campus partnerships is less explicit than in the strongest classical statements. The school does host community/donor events (Higher Purpose Gala) and admissions events that invite family participation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: partnership with families (not always phrased as such, but family involvement in admissions, shadow days), parent gatherings/donor events (Gala), open-house/admissions events; community engagement and hospitality in the event ecosystem.

- Negative keywords present: minimal explicit indication of “parents as co-teachers” or formal family formation programs; the messaging tends to present families as participants in school life rather than co-educators in a formal sense. This aligns with the Negative indicators in the Six Elements lexicon (consumer language and minimal parent formation). The current messaging indicates more involvement in events and fundraising than explicit school-as-co-educator partnerships.

Why this rating - Evidence shows strong community events and parent-admission involvement, but fewer explicit, ongoing, structured parent-formation/co-teaching programs in public messaging. This warrants SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than full CLASSICAL for Element 6.

Aggregate Assessment - The school shows pervasive CLASSICAL alignment across Categories 1–5, with Element 6 showing meaningful community involvement but lacking the strongest explicit parent-formation/co-teaching messaging. The aggregate classification is CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle - For Element 6 (Parents & Community): Introduce explicit “parents as co-educators” messaging and programs (e.g., regular classical book clubs for parents, liturgical calendar participation, home-syllabus discussions, and parent study groups modeled after classical formation practices). Create explicit “partnership with families” language on the website and in communications, and invite parents to participate in living-education initiatives beyond fundraising and events. This aligns with the Positive indicators in the Six Elements and would nudge Element 6 toward CLASSICAL. (Evidence-based cue: Six Essential Elements places a strong emphasis on parental partnership and formation; Chesterton’s visible events and admissions activities provide a ready platform to expand this dimension.) - For continued strengthening: Add publicly accessible family-facing content that frames parents as co-educators, and develop short-form family catechesis or book-study resources aligned with classical education, to deepen “Parent Formation” and “Partnership with Families” signals. (See the Six Elements; the lexicon highlights parent partnership and family formation as core Positive signals.)

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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